



Brand guidelines review 1 September 2026

The stylesheet decides where everything sits. It cannot decide what the page argues.

Reached by the stylesheet

3 of 8

Alignment, rhythm and restraint

Left to judgement

5 of 8

Including the five highest ranked

Defaults ruled out by name

17

Listed before any designing starts

This reviews the Vercel report design system as published: the brand guidelines supplied here and the vercel-brand.css foundation they load. Eight features are ranked by how much of a finished page each one settles. The ranking is an editorial reading of the guidelines; the counts beside it are measured from the stylesheet.

The eight features that decide the most

A feature ranks high when getting it wrong cannot be repaired further down the page. Read the last column as an inspection routine: each check takes under a minute and fails loudly.

Eight design features, in rank order. Rank is an editorial reading of the guidelines, not a measurement.

Feature	What it settles	Where it is enforced	How to check it
The first screen carries the argument	Whether the reader gets an answer at all	Judgement	Read only the first screen. Say what it decided.
Two reading speeds in one page	Whether skimmers and auditors both succeed	Judgement	Read the headings alone, then the tables alone.
One evidence home per claim	Whether the page repeats itself	Judgement	Search the page for the same number twice.
Geometry chosen before components	Whether a chart proves anything	Judgement	Cover each chart. Ask if a sentence would be faster.
Named defaults ruled out in advance	Whether the page looks generated	Judgement	Run the list of 17 rejected defaults against the page.
Relational spacing with one gap owner	Whether groups read as groups	Foundation	Blur the page. Check the groupings survive.
Peers share exact grid lines	Whether a comparison can be trusted	Foundation	Draw a vertical line down any repeated column.
Colour withheld until it means something	Whether emphasis follows the argument	Foundation and judgement	View it in grey. Check nothing is lost.

The break in the third column is the finding. Everything the stylesheet can enforce sits below everything that changes what the report says.

Where the foundation spends its rules

The published stylesheet holds 1,172 property declarations. Half of them place things rather than style them, and almost none of them move.

Property declarations by concern

Share of all 1,172 declarations in vercel-brand.css. Each track spans 0 to 100 percent.



Placement and spacing take 587 of the 1,172 declarations between them. Motion takes 42. Declaration counts show where the code goes, not how strongly each concern affects a finished page.

What it protects without being asked

Three of the eight features arrive already working. They are the ones a designer would otherwise have to re-earn on every page, and they are enforced by relational selectors rather than by discipline.

Relational rules

129

Spacing that changes with what a container actually holds

Subgrid declarations

7

Peer labels and values pulled onto shared grid lines

6

Every one of them grey until colour is given a meaning

The restraint is structural rather than advisory. A bar list containing a bar marked primary automatically dims every other fill, so visual weight follows the argument without anyone choosing a colour. The same holds for the interface itself: the stylesheet defines 133 classes and the guidelines publish 99 of them. The 34 that remain internal are the ones a page could use to drift.

The first screen is the whole decision

Every other feature repairs a page the reader has already begun. This one decides whether they begin. Nothing in 1,172 declarations can tell you that your opening screen is a title followed by set-up rather than the answer and the evidence that earns it.

What the stylesheet cannot check

Two reading speeds

An executive reads the headings, the decisive values and the captions. An auditor reads the tables, the assumptions and the caveats. Both paths run through the same page, and only writing decides whether either one works.

One evidence home per claim

A later table may preserve exact lookup, but a second summary, chart or conclusion must not answer the same question at equal prominence. Duplication reads as padding, and padding costs the reader trust.

Geometry before components

Magnitude becomes length on a common scale. Change over time becomes horizontal position. Composition becomes proportion. Choosing the visual variable first is what separates a chart that proves something from a chart that decorates a number.

Named defaults, ruled out early

Seventeen recognisable habits are rejected by name, from tracked eyebrows to cards inside cards. Naming them in advance is cheaper than recognising them in a finished page, when they have already set the rhythm.

Where to spend the first hour

Spend it on the opening screen, not the palette. Write the answer as the page title. Put the evidence that earns it directly beneath. Choose the primitive last. The foundation will hold the alignment, the rhythm and the restraint whether or not that hour goes well, which is exactly why the hour belongs to the part it cannot hold.

How the counts were made

Every number on this page comes from one of two places: the guidelines text supplied in the request, or the stylesheet it loads. Nothing is estimated.

Measurements taken from the published guidelines and stylesheet.

Measure	Value	Method
Property declarations	1,172	Property lines in the stylesheet, excluding custom property definitions
Custom properties defined	120	Lines opening with a double hyphen
Classes in the stylesheet	133	Distinct .vbg- class selectors

Measure	Value	Method
Classes in the published API	99	Counted across the shell, type, calculator and visualisation lists
Tokens a page may read	57	Counted across the six published token families
Relational rules	129	Selectors containing : has ()
Defaults rejected by name	17	Entries in the rejected reflexes list

The rank order is an editorial reading of the guidelines, not a measurement, and a different reader could defend a different order. Declaration counts describe how much code serves each concern, not how strongly each concern affects a finished page. The stylesheet was read at the version fetched on 1 September 2026.

Vercel brand guidelines, supplied in full with this request.

vercel-brand.css, fetched from vercel.com/geist on 1 September 2026, 108,893 bytes.

